G GAO ESSENTIALLS

Confidential Operational Guide
Prepared: November 2026
Target: Commercial Go-Live

STORE LAUNCH READINESS

Pre-Launch Operational Checklist

A step-by-step master checklist of actions required across business settings, inventory, payments, courier logistics, and deployment before opening Gao Essentialls to public customers.

STEP 01 STORE & BUSINESS INFORMATION (ADMIN SETTINGS)

- [ ] **Real Banking Details for EFT Payments** ACTION REQUIRED
  In Admin → Settings, input your verified South African business bank account (Bank Name, Account Holder, Account Number, Branch Code). These details appear on customer invoices and order confirmation screens.
- [ ] **Official WhatsApp & Telephone Numbers** ACTION REQUIRED
  Enter your primary WhatsApp Business contact number. Customers use this line to send EFT payment proofs and ask pre-purchase questions.
- [ ] **Customer Care Email Address**
  Set an active company email (e.g. `orders@gaoessentialls.co.za`) to receive customer messages from the Contact page and checkout confirmation copies.
- [ ] **Warehouse / Store Collection Address**
  Provide the exact street address in Johannesburg where customers choosing "Store Collection" will pick up their orders, along with collection hours (e.g. Mon–Fri 09:00–17:00).
- [ ] **Announcement Banner Customization**
  Update the top notification banner (e.g. "Free nationwide delivery on orders over R1,000 | Cash on Delivery available").

STEP 02 PRODUCT CATALOGUE & INVENTORY FINALIZATION

- [ ] **Audit Mock Seeded Products** ACTION REQUIRED
  Review the 41 existing sample products across Clothes, Shoes, Appliances, Pots, Bags, Blankets, Hats, and Jerseys. Delete items you don't stock or edit them to reflect actual inventory.
- [ ] **Accurate Selling & Promotional Prices**
  Confirm the correct regular retail price and optional sale/discount price in South African Rand (ZAR) for each product.
- [ ] **Initial Physical Stock Counts**
  Enter true unit counts for all items. Products with 0 stock automatically lock and show "Sold Out", while items below 5 units display an urgent "Only X left" badge.
- [ ] **Size & Colour Options Setup**
  Verify that variant selectors match your physical stock (e.g., S/M/L/XL for clothes & soccer jerseys; UK 4–11 for shoes; litre capacity like 5L/7.5L for pots and air fryers).
- [ ] **Upload Real Product Photography**
  Use the Admin photo uploader to add real multi-angle photographs for any new incoming stock (JPEG, PNG, or WEBP up to 5MB).

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STEP 03 PAYMENT METHODS & FINANCIAL WORKFLOWS

- [ ] **Cash on Delivery (COD) Rules & Validation** READY
  COD is 100% active on the store. Confirm which metropolitan zones you service for cash handling and establish an SMS/WhatsApp verification step before dispatching COD packages.
- [ ] **EFT Proof of Payment Verification Protocol**
  Establish a daily routine to check your business bank account against customer order numbers (e.g. `GAO-10045`) before changing an order's status to "Confirmed" in Admin.
- [ ] **Online Card Payment Gateway Integration** OPTIONAL
  If you wish to accept Visa/Mastercard cards and Instant EFT, create a merchant account with **PayFast**, **Yoco**, or **Ozow** and complete FICA verification.

STEP 04 COURIER LOGISTICS & PACKAGING MATERIALS

- [ ] **Courier Partner Account Setup** ACTION REQUIRED
  Open a commercial business account with a nationwide courier such as **The Courier Guy**, **Pudo**, **Fastway**, or **Aramex**.
- [ ] **Delivery Fees & Free Shipping Threshold**
  Set your flat delivery rate (e.g. R99 or R120) and your Free Shipping threshold (e.g. R1,000) in Admin → Settings to match your courier contract rates.
- [ ] **Packaging Supplies & Waybills**
  Ensure you have flyer bags, sturdy cartons, bubble wrap (critical for pots and air fryers), and label printing paper ready at your dispatch station.

STEP 05 LEGAL COMPLIANCE & SOUTH AFRICAN CONSUMER LAWS

- [ ] **Return & Refund Policy (CPA Compliant)** RECOMMENDED
  Define your return window (standard 7–14 days for unused goods in original packaging), warranty on electric appliances, and who covers return courier fees.
- [ ] **Privacy Policy (POPIA Compliant)**
  State that customer names, physical addresses, and contact numbers are stored securely and used solely for fulfilling orders and courier delivery.

STEP 06 SECURITY, DOMAIN & 24/7 CLOUD DEPLOYMENT

- [ ] **Change Default Admin Password** ACTION REQUIRED
  The current default password is `Admin@123`. Change this immediately to a secure 12+ character private password.
- [ ] **Register Official Domain Name**
  Acquire `gaoessentialls.co.za` (or `.com`) through Domains.co.za, Namecheap, or 1-grid.
- [ ] **Deploy to 24/7 Cloud Server**
  Deploy to a cost-effective cloud VPS (DigitalOcean/Hetzner ~$5/month) or Vercel so the store runs around the clock with free SSL (HTTPS) encryption.
- [ ] **Live Dry-Run Test Order**
  Place an actual order on your smartphone, check the receipt, confirm it appears in the Admin dashboard, and verify the order tracker updates cleanly.

Immediate Access Details:

- Storefront: `http://localhost:3000`
- Admin Dashboard: `http://localhost:3001/login` (Email: `admin@gaoessentialls.co.za`)
- All product uploads and order updates sync automatically between the dashboard and storefront.

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